

Setting Up the File

Preparing InDesign Before You Build Anything

A grid means nothing on top of a messy file.

Before we build anything, InDesign has to be set up like a professional environment.

Why Today Matters

Baseline grids, margins, and modules all live inside an InDesign file, and none of them work if the file underneath is a mess. Today is not about the grid. It's about the file the grid will eventually sit inside.

- 1 Configure a new document with the right units, size, and page setup**
- 2 Reset your workspace, then activate and organize the panels you'll actually use**
- 3 Set up parent pages for the page types that repeat across your portfolio**
- 4 Organize content into a locked, non-printing four-layer system**
- 5 Save the whole setup as a workspace you can reload every class**

Document Setup

Before anything else exists, a document has to. Every setting here becomes the foundation the rest of the term builds on.

Units

Set to Points, under Preferences > Units & Increments.

Facing Pages

Turn on, so spreads behave like a real printed book.

Page Size

Set to match your storyboard, not a placeholder default.

WHY IT MATTERS

Units, page size, and facing pages can't be changed painlessly later, everything placed after this point measures itself against these settings.

Get this wrong and every margin, image, and text box you place has to be re-measured by hand.

The Workspace Reset

Old panels from old projects clutter your screen and slow you down. Start every new file the same way: a blank slate.

- 1 Go to the Workspace Switcher, in the top-right corner**
- 2 Select Essentials, then select Reset Essentials**
- 3 This clears old clutter and gives you a blank slate to build your system**

Activate Your Core Panels

Open the specific tools this setup requires, all from the Window menu.

PANEL	PATH	WHAT IT'S FOR
Pages & Layers	Window > Pages, Window > Layers	Your primary navigation and structural hierarchy tools
Links	Window > Links	Tracks your placed project images and external drawings
Align	Window > Object & Layout > Align	Positions elements precisely relative to each other
Paragraph Styles	Window > Styles > Paragraph Styles	Your most important tool for maintaining consistent type
Properties	Window > Properties	Shows every attribute of your selected object in one place

Parent Page Architecture

Parent pages are repeating page templates. Set one up once, and every page built from it, present and future, updates automatically.

A · INTRO PARENT

A minimal layout for the project title splash page: the entry point for each project section.

Elements

Project title area, date/location, minimal page number.

Page number

Type > Insert Special Character > Markers > Current Page Number

B · PROJECT PARENT

The standard content layout, with a fixed project title placeholder the reader can always return to for orientation. No margins or grid guides yet, that's next class.

Elements

Running header, page number, content placeholder.

The Four-Layer System

Everything you place belongs on one of four layers, always in this stacking order, top to bottom.

LAYER	STACK POSITION	WHAT GOES HERE
04_Text	Top	Titles, descriptions, page numbers. Kept on top so type is never buried under an image.
03_Images	Upper middle	Renderings, photographs, and site photos. Isolated here so you can preflight and swap links without touching text.
02_Drawings	Lower middle	Plans, sections, elevations, and diagrams: technical line work, kept separate from photographic images so either can be shown or hidden on its own.
01_Guides	Bottom, non-printing	Placeholder boxes and alignment markers. Lock this layer and uncheck Print Layer so it never appears in the exported PDF.

Organize the Dock

A scattered workspace works against you. Group and dock your panels so the tools you need are always exactly where you expect them.

- 1 Group Panels:** drag one panel's tab onto another until a blue highlight appears, then release
- 2 Docking:** drag the whole group to the right edge of the screen until a blue bar appears
- 3 Collapse to Icons:** click the double-arrow at the top of the dock for more screen space

Save Your Workspace

Do this once and you never have to rebuild your panel setup again, every file for the rest of the term can open into exactly this layout.

HOW TO SAVE IT

1. Go to the Workspace Switcher > New Workspace
2. Name it something you'll recognize, e.g. "Portfolio System"
3. It now appears in the Workspace Switcher every time you open InDesign

WHAT'S NEXT

No grid work today, no baseline, no margins, no columns.
That's next class: the 12-point baseline and modular grid, built on top of the file you set up today.

Quick Reference

Keep this open while you work.

ACTION	MAC	WINDOWS
Preview Mode	W	W
Open Preferences	Cmd+K	Ctrl+K
Show/Hide Guides	Cmd+;	Ctrl+;
Snap to Guides	Shift+Cmd+;	Shift+Ctrl+;
Place File	Cmd+D	Ctrl+D
Fit Spread in Window	Opt+Cmd+0	Alt+Ctrl+0